Code of Conduct

This Code of Conduct applies to GPAK staff, Advisory Committee members, volunteers, mentor mothers, community volunteers, interns, consultants and visitors. It sets out how everyone connected to GPAK must behave towards participants, their families, colleagues and the community, across all of GPAK's programmes. It works together with the Safeguarding and PSEA Policy (POL-01), the Anti-Fraud, Bribery and Corruption Policy (POL-05) and the Conflict of Interest Policy (POL-07).

1 Respect and non-discrimination

Everyone connected to GPAK must:

- Treat every participant, colleague and community member with dignity and respect.
- Never discriminate on the basis of HIV status, pregnancy, disability, age, marital status, ethnicity, religion or any other characteristic.
- Use respectful, non-judgemental language, including about HIV status, pregnancy and sexual health.

Must never:

- Mock, shame, threaten or humiliate a participant or colleague.
- Treat a participant differently because of her HIV status, pregnancy or history of violence.

2 Child and adult safeguarding

Everyone connected to GPAK must follow the Safeguarding and PSEA Policy (POL-01) in full, including its rules on home visits, group sessions, transport and reporting. Must never investigate a disclosure, promise confidentiality, or handle a safeguarding concern without reporting it to the Safeguarding Focal Point.

3 Sexual exploitation and abuse: zero tolerance

- No sexual relationship with any participant, regardless of her age or apparent consent.
- No exchange of money, help, goods, services or preferential treatment for sex or sexual favours, with a participant or anyone else connected to GPAK's work.
- No sexual activity with any person under 18, regardless of local age of consent; a mistaken belief about age is never a defence.
- No sexual relationship that involves improper use of rank or position over a person benefiting from GPAK's assistance.

Breach of this section is gross misconduct and grounds for immediate termination or removal, and may be reported to the police.

4 Confidentiality

- Keep confidential anything learned about a participant's HIV status, pregnancy, experience of violence, or other personal circumstances.
- Share such information only with the people who need it to provide support, through GPAK's agreed channels, or as the law requires.
- Never discuss a participant's situation with family members, neighbours, other participants or on social media.

5 Photographs and social media

- Take or use a photograph, video or story involving a participant only with the separate consent required by the Ethical Storytelling, Photography and Media Consent Policy (POL-11).

- Never post a participant's image, name or story on personal social media.
- Never contact a participant through personal social media or accept a friend or follow request to or from a participant.

6 WhatsApp peer circles and digital contact

- Create and moderate every WhatsApp peer circle from a GPAK phone, never a personal number, and only if trained to do so as a staff member or mentor mother.
- Let a participant join a WhatsApp peer circle only by her own consent, and let her leave at any time without any effect on her other support.
- Never name, or allow, a group name that refers to HIV, pregnancy or any health condition.
- Never share another member's health status, photographs, location or personal story in a group, and never give clinical advice in a group.
- Remove a breaching message promptly and report a serious breach to the Safeguarding Focal Point.

7 Use of GPAK money, phones and airtime

- Use GPAK funds, phones and airtime only for GPAK business, following the Financial Management Policy (POL-08) and Procurement Policy (POL-09).
- Account for any advance or float promptly, with accurate receipts.
- Never ask a participant for money, gifts or favours in exchange for support or information.

8 Gifts and hospitality

Follow the limits and disclosure rules in the Anti-Fraud, Bribery and Corruption Policy (POL-05) and the Conflict of Interest Policy (POL-07). Never accept a gift, payment or favour from a participant, supplier or partner that could influence, or appear to influence, a decision made on GPAK's behalf.

9 Alcohol and drugs

No one may consume alcohol or use non-prescribed drugs while on GPAK duty, at a GPAK activity, or immediately before contact with a participant.

10 Transport of participants

No one connected to GPAK transports a participant alone in private transport, other than an escorted referral logged in advance and agreed with the Programs Officer, at the participant's own request.

11 Working alone with a child

Avoid being alone with a participant under 18 in a private or closed setting. Prefer a public or semi-public setting, or the presence of a second GPAK-connected person, for any meeting with a participant under 18, in line with the home-visit rules in POL-01.

12 Counselling sessions

- Hold counselling in a setting private enough for the participant to speak freely, but visible enough that a colleague could see that a session is taking place.
- Provide counselling only if trained as a counsellor. Anyone who is not a trained counsellor refers a participant needing this support to one, or to a qualified mental health professional for clinical care.

13 Menstrual health support

Provide menstrual health education and distribute sanitary pads discreetly, never in a way that identifies to others, including other participants, who is receiving this support.

14 Family mediation

- Offer family mediation only where the participant herself wants it and a safety assessment shows it will not put her at greater risk.
- Never pressure a participant to reconcile with, or accept mediation with, a family member she does not want involved, and stop mediation immediately if she asks.

15 School visits

- Arrange a school visit with the school in advance, for an agreed purpose such as re-entry negotiation or attendance follow-up.
- Never discuss a participant's HIV status, pregnancy or other sensitive information with school staff without her specific consent.

16 Duty to report

Everyone connected to GPAK must report any safeguarding concern, breach of this Code, suspected fraud or conflict of interest, through the channels in POL-01, POL-05, POL-06 (Whistleblowing) or POL-07. Reporting in good faith is protected: no one is penalised for raising a genuine concern, even if it later proves unfounded.

17 Role limits for mentor mothers and community volunteers

Mentor mothers and community volunteers provide practical, relational support. They must never:

- Give clinical advice or a clinical opinion.
- Hold, copy or store a participant's clinical or facility records.
- Decide whether a disclosure is true, or investigate it.
- Present themselves as GPAK staff with authority they do not have.

18 Consequences of breach

A breach of this Code may lead to retraining, a formal warning, suspension from contact with participants, termination of employment or engagement, removal from a community role, referral to the police or the Sub-County Children's Officer, and, for SEA, immediate termination and referral to the authorities. The response follows the safeguarding procedure in POL-01 where the breach concerns a child or adult at risk.

Approval and review

Item	Detail
Policy owner	Director
Approved by	Advisory Committee
Applies to	All GPAK staff, Advisory Committee members, volunteers, mentor mothers, community volunteers, interns, consultants, contractors and partners working on GPAK activities
Review	Every two years, or earlier if the law, a funder requirement or an incident review shows that a change is needed.

Public copy. Internal forms, annexes and signature pages are kept on file by GPAK and are available on request.